Exchanging Greetings

Dialogue 1

At school, Wang Peng and Li You meet each other for the first time.

Audio

Video

你好[a]！

你好！

请问[b]，你[c]贵姓？

我姓[1]*李。你呢[2]？

我姓王。李小姐[d]，你叫[3]什么名字？

我叫李友。王先生，你叫什么名字？

我叫王朋[4]。

Pinyin Dialogue

Nǐ hǎo[a]!

Nǐ hǎo!

Qǐng wèn[b], *nǐ*[c] *guì xìng?*

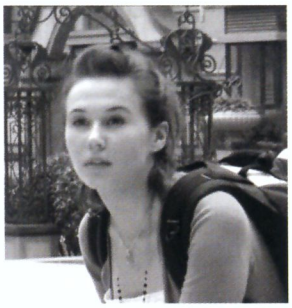
Wǒ xìng[1] *Lǐ. Nǐ ne*[2]*?*

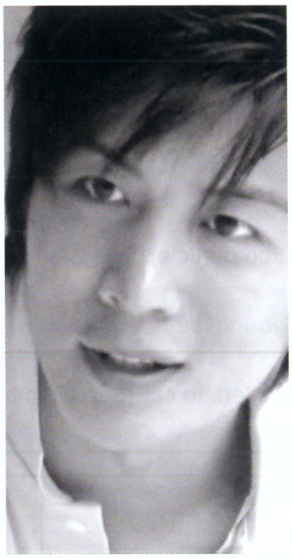
Wǒ xìng Wáng. Lǐ xiǎojiě[d], *nǐ jiào*[3] *shénme míngzi?*

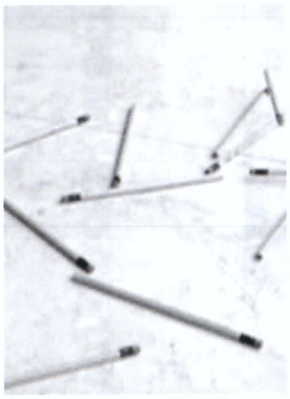
Wǒ jiào Lǐ Yǒu. Wáng xiānsheng, nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?

Wǒ jiào Wáng Péng[4].

* Here and throughout the book, the blue lesson text and numbers correspond to explanations in the **Grammar section.**







a 你好! *(Nǐ hǎo!)*

This common greeting is used to address strangers as well as old acquaintances. To respond, simply repeat the same greeting.

b 请问 *(qǐng wèn)*

This is a polite phrase used to get someone's attention before asking a question or making an inquiry, similar to "excuse me, may I ask" in English.

c 你 *(nǐ)* vs. 您 *(nín)*

To be more polite and respectful, replace 你 *(nǐ)* with its honorific form, 您 *(nín)*. [See Language Note A, Dialogue 1, Lesson 6.]

d 小姐 *(xiǎojiě)*

This is a word with two third-tone syllables. The tone sandhi rule applies, thus making the first third tone, 小 *(xiǎo)*, a second tone. The second syllable, 姐 *(jiě)*, can also be pronounced in the neutral tone.

Vocabulary

Audio

Flashcards

No.	Word	Pinyin	Part of Speech	Definition
1	你	*nǐ*	pr	you
2	好	*hǎo*	adj	fine, good, nice, OK, it's settled
3	请	*qǐng*	v	please (polite form of request), to treat or to invite (somebody)
4	问	*wèn*	v	to ask (a question)
5	贵	*guì*	adj	honorable, expensive
6	姓	*xìng*	v/n	(one's) family name is . . . ; family name [See Grammar 1.]
7	我	*wǒ*	pr	I, me
8	呢	*ne*	qp	(question particle) [See Grammar 2.]
9	小姐	*xiǎojiě*	n	Miss, young lady
10	叫	*jiào*	v	to be called, to call [See Grammar 3.]
11	什么	*shénme*	qpr	what
12	名字	*míngzi*	n	name
13	先生	*xiānsheng*	n	Mr., husband, teacher
14	李友	*Lǐ Yǒu*	pn	(a personal name)
	李	*lǐ*	pn/n	(a family name); plum
15	王朋	*Wáng Péng*	pn	(a personal name)
	王	*wáng*	pn/n	(a family name); king

How About You?

你叫什么名字？

Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?

What is your name?

我叫 _____。

Wǒ jiào _____.

Grammar

1 The verb 姓 (*xìng*)

姓 (*xìng*) is both a noun and a verb. When it is used as a verb, it must be followed by an object.

A Q: 你姓什么？ A: 我姓李。

Nǐ xìng shénme? *Wǒ xìng Lǐ.*

What is your family name? My family name is Li.

姓 (*xìng*) is usually negated with 不 (*bù*). [See Grammar 7.]

B Q: 你姓李吗？ A: 我不姓李。 [✗ 我不姓。]

Nǐ xìng Lǐ ma? *Wǒ bú xìng Lǐ.*

Is your family name Li? My family name is not Li.

The polite way to ask for and give a family name is as follows.

C Q: 你贵姓？ [✗ 你贵姓什么？]

Nǐ guì xìng?

What is your family name?
(Lit. Your honorable family name is . . . ?)

Remember to drop the honorific 贵 (*guì*) when you reply.

A: 我姓王。 [✗ 我贵姓王。]

Wǒ xìng Wáng.

My family name is Wang.

You can also respond to 你贵姓 (*nǐ guì xìng*) by saying 免贵姓王 (*miǎn guì xìng Wáng*), 免贵姓李 (*miǎn guì xìng Lǐ*). (Lit. Dispense with "honorable." [My] family name is Wang/Li.)

EXERCISES

Complete these exchanges with your own family name.

1 Q: 请问，你贵姓？ A: 我姓_____。

2 Q: 你姓什么？ A: 我姓_____。

2 Questions ending with 呢 *(ne)*

呢 *(ne)* often follows a noun or pronoun to form a question when the content of the question is already clear from the context.

A

Q: 请问，你贵姓？
Qǐng wèn, nǐ guì xìng?
What's your family name, please?

A: 我姓李，你呢？
Wǒ xìng Lǐ, nǐ ne?
My family name is Li. How about you?

B

Q: 你叫什么名字？
Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?
What's your name?

A: 我叫王朋，你呢？
Wǒ jiào Wáng Péng, nǐ ne?
My name is Wang Peng. How about you?

When 呢 *(ne)* is used in this way, there must be some context. In each of the two examples above, the context is provided by the preceding sentence: 我姓李 *(wǒ xìng Lǐ)* in (A), and 我叫王朋 *(wǒ jiào Wáng Péng)* in (B).

You're at the first meeting of your college's Chinese Student Association. What is this sophomore's name?

EXERCISES

In pairs, ask and give your name and family name.

1 Q: 我姓_____，你呢？ A: 我姓_____。

2 Q: 我叫_____，你呢？ A: 我叫_____。

3 The verb 叫 (*jiào*)

While 叫 (*jiào*) has several meanings, it means "to be called" in this lesson. Like 姓 (*xìng*), it must be followed by an object, which can be either a full name or a given name, but seldom a given name that consists only of one syllable.

A Q: 你叫什么名字？ A: 我叫王小朋。

Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi? *Wǒ jiào Wáng Xiǎopéng.*

What is your name? My name is Wang Xiaopeng.

叫 (*jiào*) is usually negated with 不 (*bù*). [See Grammar 7.]

B Q: 你叫李生吗？ A: 我不叫李生。

Nǐ jiào Lǐ Shēng ma? *Wǒ bú jiào Lǐ Shēng.*

Is your name Li Sheng? My name is not Li Sheng.

EXERCISES

Take turns answering the questions below.

1 Q: 请问，你叫什么名字？ A: 我叫_____。

2 Q: 你叫李好吗？ A: 我不叫_____。

4 Subject + verb + object

From the examples in the previous Grammar Points, we can see that the basic word order in a Chinese sentence is subject + verb + object.

The word order remains the same in statements and questions. You don't place the question word at the beginning of a question as you do in English, unless that question word is the subject. [See also Grammar 3, Lesson 2, and Grammar 1, Lesson 4.]

Language Practice

A Mix and mingle

INTERPERSONAL

Introduce yourself to your classmates using the outline below.

Student A 你好！

Nǐ hǎo!

Student B _____。

_____.

Student A 请问，你贵姓？

Qǐng wèn, nǐ guì xìng?

Student B 我姓 _____。你呢？

Wǒ xìng _____. *Nǐ ne?*

Student A 我姓 _____，我叫 _____。你叫什么名字？

Wǒ xìng _____, *wǒ jiào* _____. *Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?*

Student B 我叫 _____。

Wǒ jiào _____.

Characterize it!

Unitary

1 小 2 请 3 王 4 生 5 贵

Which of these characters are formed with the pattern on the left?

More characters

B Getting acquainted

INTERPERSONAL

Complete the following exchange between two people who have never met before. Do a role-play based on the prompts.

Student A 你好！

Nǐ hǎo!

Student B _____。

_____.

Student A 我姓 _____，请问，你贵姓？

Wǒ xìng _____, *qǐng wèn, nǐ guì xìng?*

Student B _____。

_____.

Student A _____，你叫什么名字？

_____, *nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?*

Student B 我叫 _____。

Wǒ jiào _____.

Chinese Chat

You want to add Wang Peng and Li You to a group text message. From this contact list, which names would you select?